



Jonathan Selvaraj

jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

Manikanta Hoblidhar thought he had it. Having set the national 100m record of 10.23 seconds just a few months earlier at the 2023 Open National Championships, he felt well-positioned to improve on that mark even further. Running in the final of the men's 100m at the National Games in Goa, the then 21-year-old had begun perfectly. As he surged towards the finish line, he stormed to a lead that had stretched, by his estimate, to some four metres ahead of the rest of the field.

That's when he felt a twinge in his right hamstring. His momentum all but vanished, and Manikanta eventually limped over the finish line in fourth place. "I still clocked 10.42 seconds after the injury. If I had been able to run all the way through to the finish line, I'm sure I'd have run in less than 10.20 seconds," he says.

As it stands, 10.23 seconds remains the Indian record in men's 100m. (This year, the fastest time clocked by an Indian was 10.27 seconds, recorded by Animesh Kujur.)

It's a mark that few are satisfied with. "The 100m is the most important event in international athletics. It's the one race that everyone watches. There's no reason the best time in India should be as high as it is," says Kujur. There's good reason for this. Manikanta's national record places him 1427th among 100m sprinters. Among all track and field events, India's men's 100m record ranks as the lowest.

It's a fact that has surprised Martin Owens, head coach of the Reliance Foundation Youth Sport High Performance Centre in Odisha, when he first examined the figures. "I would say that running in India is underdeveloped in comparison with the technical events. So if you take events like the long jump, triple jump, or javelin throw, the national records in India are world-class. The same is not true for the running events, particularly the sprints. You would think it would be the other way around. When I saw that, it didn't make sense to me. I thought, there must be some running talent in India, there must be!" he says.

The genes argument

While there's an argument that genetic limitations perhaps explain India's lack of success in the sprints, not all sports scientists



India's four fastest runners – Gurindervir Singh, Manikanta Hoblidhar, Animesh Kujur and Amlan Borgohain – are training at Reliance Foundation's High Performance Centre in Mumbai.